Elder Wisdom

What They Told Us When We Finally Listened

RELENTLESS

INTRODUCTION

You already know the voice I'm talking about. It came from the porch or the kitchen or the front pew, and it usually started with "Let me tell you something." You were young. You nodded. You didn't listen.

Then life came and collected on every lesson you skipped.

That's how most of us learn what elders know. Not when they say it. Years later, standing in a parking lot or a hospital hallway or an empty apartment, when the words come back in their exact tone of voice, and we finally understand them.

[Relentless: put your own moment here. Name the elder, the place and the sentence they said that you didn't understand until later. Two or three sentences. Keep it plain.]

This book is for the people who carried that wisdom and the people who are only now ready to receive it. The faces in these pages are drawn with a little exaggeration (big glasses, big hair, bigger opinions) because that's how memory draws the ones we love. Every one of them has the same quiet confidence. They aren't guessing. They've been there.

So sit down. Pour something warm. Let them tell you something.

CHAPTER 1

The Porch Is a Classroom

Aunt Birdie kept a pencil in her bun. Nobody alive had seen her write with it.

The porch was her classroom, and she didn't take attendance. You came up the three steps and sat where she pointed, usually the low stool by the rail, so she could look down at you over the top of those wire glasses. Then she waited. That was the first lesson, and most of the children on Calloway Street failed it every summer: Birdie didn't talk until you stopped talking.

"You came up here with something on your mind," she'd say. "Put it down."

So you put it down. The boy who stole from the corner store. The girl whose mama wasn't coming back from Detroit. The teenager who thought he was too smart for school and wanted somebody to agree with him. Birdie listened to every one of them the same way, hands folded in her lap, rocking a little, saying nothing until the story ran out of road.

Pops Earl lived two doors down and liked to say that Birdie never gave advice. "She just asks you one question," he'd say, "and you walk home with your own answer stuck in your shoe."

He was right. To the boy who stole, she asked, "Who'd you want to see you do it?" He said nobody. She waited. He said his older brother. She nodded like that settled it, and in a way it did. To the teenager who was too smart for school, she asked, "Who's going to pay you to be smart in your own head?" He laughed. Then he stopped laughing.

There's a reason the porch worked when the classroom didn't. A porch sits halfway between the house and the street, between private and public, between who you are at home and who you pretend to be outside. On a porch, you could tell the truth and still leave whenever you wanted. Birdie never kept anybody. She just made it easy to stay.

What she understood, and what most of us figure out too late, is that wisdom is mostly patience with a good chair. She didn't know more facts than the teachers at Lincoln Elementary. She knew more people. Eighty-four years of watching folks make the same five mistakes in different shoes. When you've seen a story end enough times, you can hear the ending coming from the first sentence.

The summer I'm thinking of, a girl named Toya came up the steps every afternoon for two weeks and never said a word. She sat on the stool. Birdie rocked. The ice in their glasses melted. On the fifteenth day, Toya finally said, "I don't think I'm smart."

Birdie took the pencil out of her bun for the first time anybody could remember and handed it to her.

"Then write down what you notice," she said. "Smart is just noticing, written down."

Toya is a nurse practitioner now. She still has the pencil.

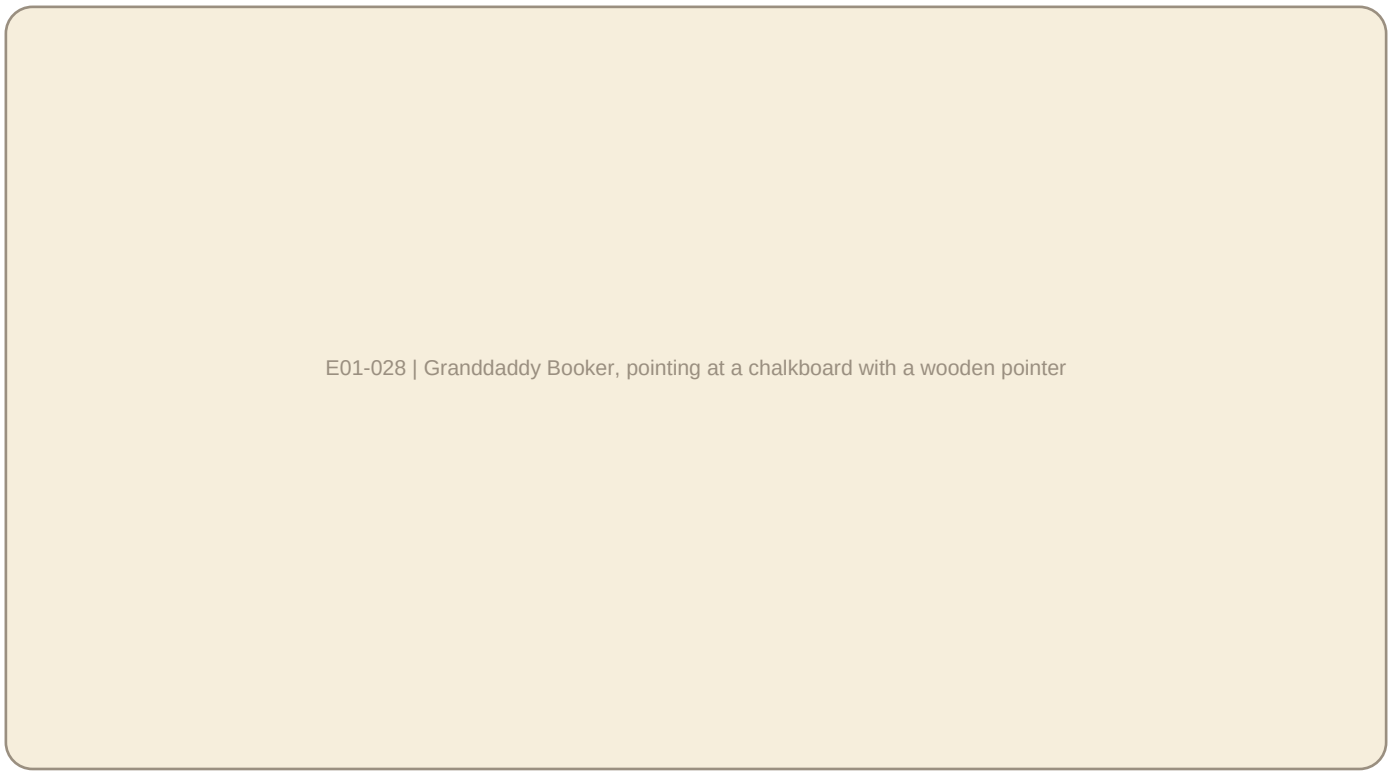
You had a porch too, even if it was a stoop, a barbershop chair or the back seat of somebody's Buick. Somebody sat there waiting for you to stop talking. The question this chapter wants to leave you with is simple, and it's Birdie's: what did they ask you that you're still answering?

E01-012 | Granddaddy Booker, peering over the top of their glasses with a knowing look

He doesn't have to say it. You already know.

E01-025 | Miss Lula Mae, holding an old pocket watch up to show it

"Time is the only thing I can't get back, so I don't spend it on foolishness."



Lesson one: stop talking long enough to hear the lesson.



She taught thirty-one years and never once raised her voice.



Keep a little light on for whoever's still finding their way.



Earned at fifty-eight. Framed at fifty-eight and a half.



Some things you only know with your eyes closed.



You don't need a map if you know which way is right.



North is wherever your people are.



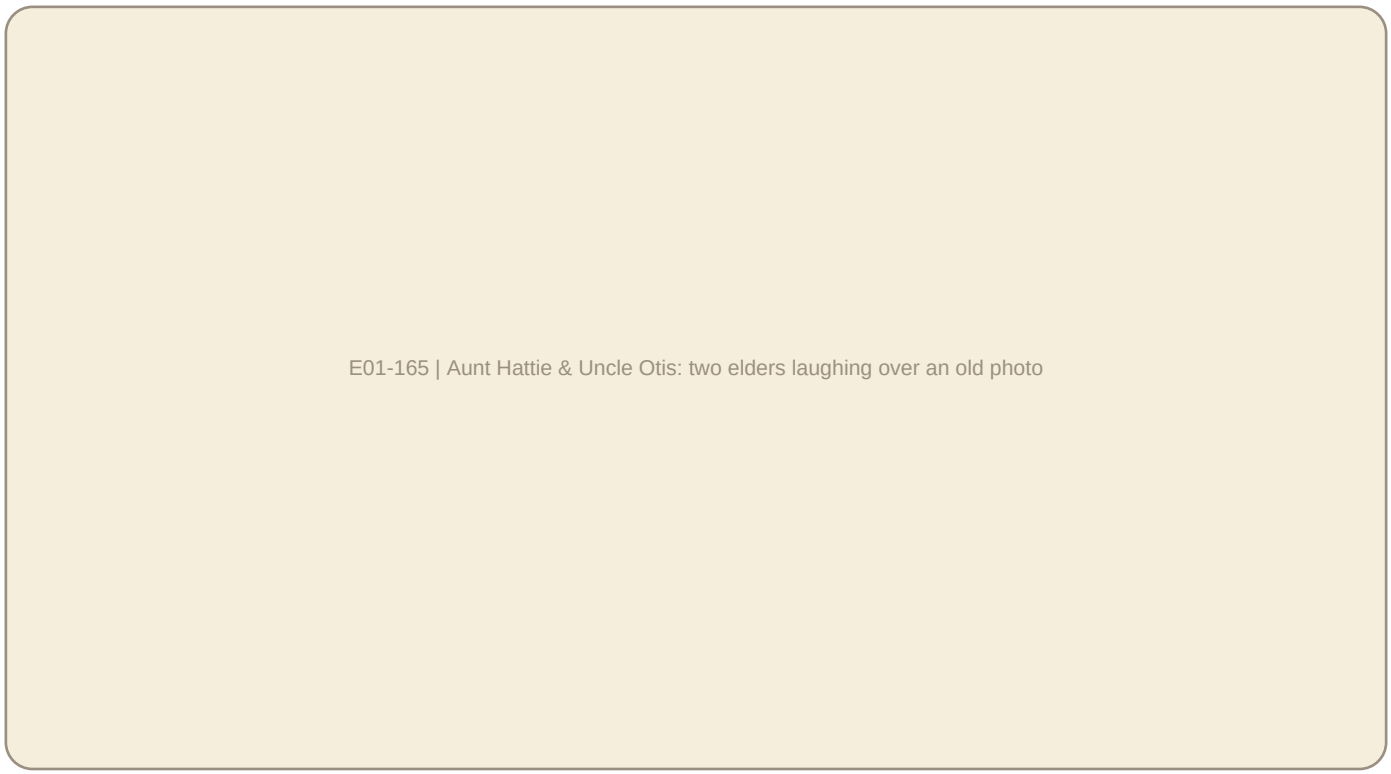
You can't go to church looking like you slept in the car. Hold still.



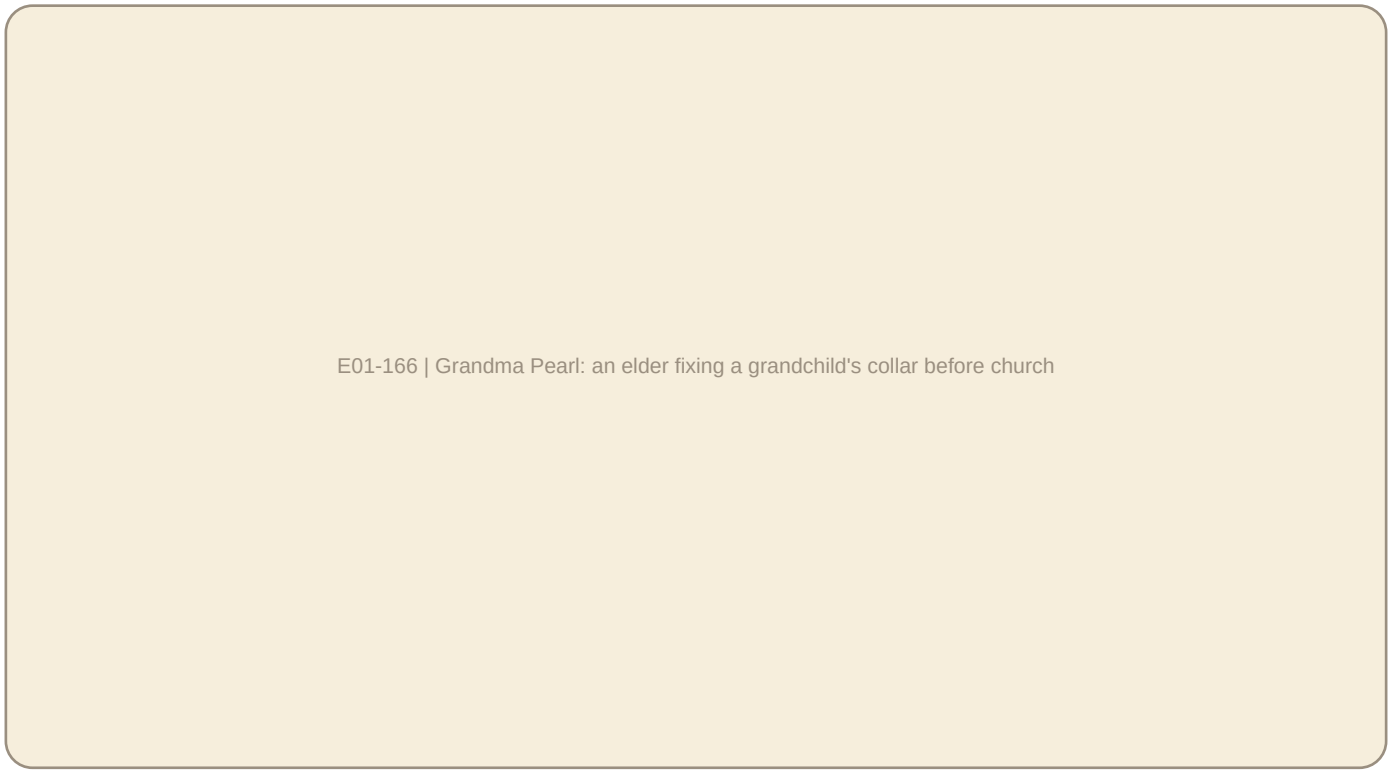
Fifty-two years. Still choosing each other on purpose.



"Don't open it till I'm gone. Fine. Open it now. I want to see your face."



Nobody laughs like people who remember the same thing.



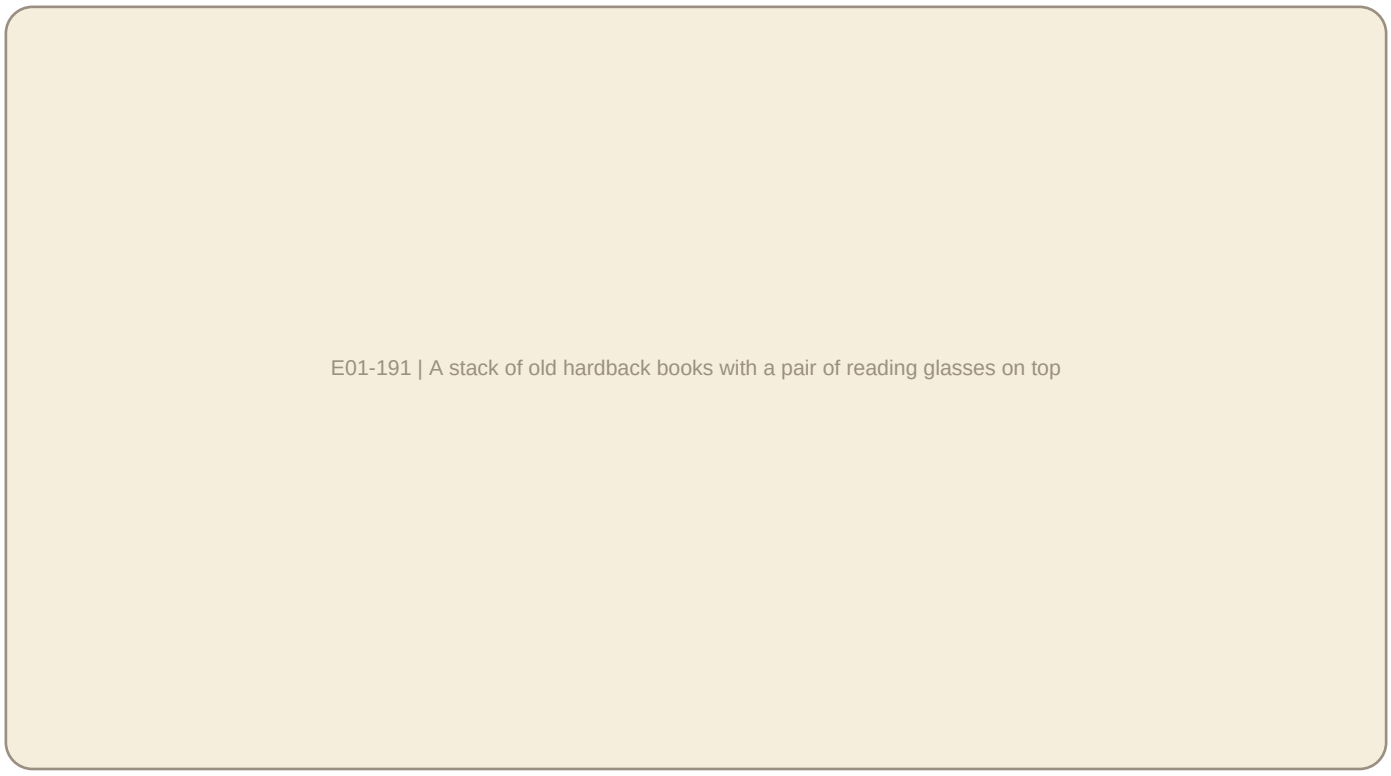
Straighten up. People are watching, and so is God.



Slow is still moving.



Ask them a foolish question. We dare you.



Read the old ones. They already argued about everything you're arguing about.



Smart is just noticing, written down.



Sit. Sip. Listen.



Every letter she ever sent was typed on this. Every one.

E01-201 | A wooden walking cane with a carved handle

The cane is for balance. The look is for you.

E01-208 | A bundle of letters tied with twine

The good ones never got thrown away.

E01-209 | A magnifying glass

Look closer.

E01-219 | A rolled map tied with string

The way back is always on the map. You just have to unroll it.

E01-234 | Word art: "Old Soul"

Old soul.

CHAPTER 2

What the Hard Years Taught

Pops Earl didn't talk about 1974. Miss Mavis did it for him.

"That was the year the plant closed," she'd say, setting the cornbread down like it was evidence. "That was the year this man learned how to fix every single thing in this house, because we couldn't pay anybody to do it."

Pops would grunt and reach for the butter. But if you watched him close, you'd see his hand go to his shirt pocket, where he kept a small notebook with a pencil clipped to the spine. In 1974 that notebook held the budget. Every dollar, every week, written in a hand so careful it looked typed. Fifty years later, it still held something. Phone numbers. A grocery list. A note to call his sister.

The hard years teach in a different voice than the easy ones. Easy years teach you what you like. Hard years teach you what you can do without, and which people stay in the room when there's nothing on the table.

Mavis says the hardest lesson that year wasn't money. It was pride. Pops had been the man who paid for things. Now he was the man who went to the church pantry on Thursday with his hat pulled low. He hated it. She didn't make him talk about it. She walked with him every Thursday, and every Thursday she talked loud and easy to everybody in line, so nobody had room to stare at him.

"Shame grows in the quiet," she said. "So I made noise."

Ask anybody who came through a hard season with somebody beside them and they'll tell you the same thing. They don't remember the details of the struggle. They remember who walked with them on Thursdays.

E01-014 | Pops Earl, peering over the top of their glasses with a knowing look

E01-015 | Miss Mavis, peering over the top of their glasses with a knowing look

E01-017 | Aunt Birdie, writing in a leather journal with a fountain pen

E01-026 | Mr. Reggie, pointing at a chalkboard with a wooden pointer

E01-030 | Pops Earl, pointing at a chalkboard with a wooden pointer

E01-045 | Miss Vivian, holding an old family photo album open

E01-049 | Aunt Birdie, standing with hands folded behind the back, looking up at the sky

E01-057 | Miss Lula Mae, carrying a basket of seeds

E01-065 | Aunt Birdie, holding a magnifying glass up to one eye

E01-067 | Mother Gloria, sitting on a porch step with elbows on the knees, listening

E01-071 | Miss Odessa, holding a framed diploma with pride

E01-096 | Deacon Ross, holding a compass in an open palm

E01-103 | Miss Odessa, showing a key on a ribbon

E01-104 | Brother Walter, showing a key on a ribbon

E01-133 | Deacon Ross: an elder teaching a grandchild to tie a tie

E01-138 | Grandma Pearl: an elder showing a teenager how to balance a checkbook

E01-153 | Miss Mavis & Coach Clarence: two elders laughing over an old photo

E01-155 | Aunt Hattie: an elder and a grandchild fishing off a short dock

E01-162 | Miss Odessa: an elder showing a teenager how to balance a checkbook

E01-163 | Brother Walter & Aunt Birdie: an elder couple walking arm in arm, one pointing ahead

E01-175 | Group: three elders reading the same newspaper over each other's shoulders

E01-196 | A porch swing

E01-206 | A pair of round reading glasses

E01-215 | A quilt folded in a square

E01-249 | Word art: "Sit Down, Let Me Tell You"

“Sit Down, Let Me Tell You”

CHAPTER 3

Money, Mind and Manners

[Story for 'Money, Mind and Manners' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 3' in the manuscript file.]

E01-009 | Miss Lula Mae, reading a thick worn book with a cup of tea balanced on the knee

E01-040 | Brother Walter, tapping their temple with a smile, as if saying 'think'

E01-053 | Grandma Pearl, holding a candle in a brass holder

E01-060 | Granddaddy Booker, carrying a basket of seeds

E01-068 | Mr. Jasper, sitting on a porch step with elbows on the knees, listening

E01-070 | Coach Clarence, sitting on a porch step with elbows on the knees, listening

E01-087 | Miss Odessa, shuffling a deck of cards like a teacher about to explain the game

E01-088 | Brother Walter, shuffling a deck of cards like a teacher about to explain the game

E01-089 | Miss Lula Mae, shuffling a deck of cards like a teacher about to explain the game

E01-106 | Mr. Reggie, holding a map rolled under one arm

E01-110 | Pops Earl, holding a map rolled under one arm

E01-116 | Mr. Jasper, holding a cup of coffee and laughing softly

E01-119 | Miss Odessa, holding a cup of coffee and laughing softly

E01-120 | Brother Walter, holding a cup of coffee and laughing softly

E01-134 | Deacon Ross & Miss Odessa: two elders playing chess on a small folding table

E01-150 | Coach Clarence: an elder showing a teenager how to balance a checkbook

E01-174 | Group: an elder circle on folding chairs, one holding a talking stick

E01-179 | Group: three elders sitting on a bench, all with arms crossed and the same expression

E01-188 | Group: an elder couple with two grandchildren holding hands in a chain

E01-225 | A vintage alarm clock

E01-228 | A jar of honey with a dipper

E01-229 | A stack of vinyl records

E01-230 | An owl perched on a book

E01-237 | Word art: "I Told You So"

“I Told You So”

E01-243 | Word art: "Still Learning"

“Still Learning”

CHAPTER 4

On Love That Lasts

[Story for 'On Love That Lasts' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 4' in the manuscript file.]

E01-023 | Miss Odessa, holding an old pocket watch up to show it

E01-036 | Mr. Jasper, tapping their temple with a smile, as if saying 'think'

E01-063 | Miss Mavis, holding a magnifying glass up to one eye

E01-074 | Mr. Reggie, holding a framed diploma with pride

E01-079 | Miss Mavis, with a hand over the heart, eyes closed

E01-082 | Uncle Otis, holding an antique oil lantern

E01-100 | Mr. Jasper, holding a compass in an open palm

E01-109 | Miss Vivian, holding a map rolled under one arm

E01-132 | Uncle Otis & Grandma Pearl: an elder couple leaning their foreheads together

E01-143 | Mr. Reggie: an elder and a grandchild fishing off a short dock

E01-154 | Mr. Jasper: an elder fixing a grandchild's collar before church

E01-161 | Miss Odessa & Pops Earl: two elders sharing a park bench, one telling a story with big hand gestures

E01-169 | Mother Gloria: an elder teaching a grandchild to tie a tie

E01-176 | Group: four elders at a graduation, clapping

E01-181 | Group: three elders on a porch swing deep in conversation

E01-183 | Group: three elders posing for a group picture, one squinting at the camera

E01-195 | An antique oil lantern glowing

E01-202 | A key on a ribbon

E01-204 | A small oak sapling in a clay pot

E01-210 | An hourglass

E01-211 | A vintage radio

E01-214 | A candle in a brass holder

E01-216 | A mason jar of sweet tea

E01-235 | Word art: "Slow Down, Baby"

“Slow Down, Baby”



“Know Better, Do Better”

CHAPTER 5

Patience Is a Muscle

[Story for 'Patience Is a Muscle' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 5' in the manuscript file.]

E01-021 | Grandma Pearl, holding an old pocket watch up to show it

E01-035 | Mother Gloria, holding a stack of handwritten letters tied with string

E01-039 | Miss Odessa, tapping their temple with a smile, as if saying 'think'

E01-047 | Miss Mavis, standing with hands folded behind the back, looking up at the sky

E01-052 | Mr. Jasper, holding a candle in a brass holder

E01-066 | Uncle Otis, sitting on a porch step with elbows on the knees, listening

E01-069 | Grandma Pearl, sitting on a porch step with elbows on the knees, listening

E01-073 | Miss Lula Mae, holding a framed diploma with pride

E01-086 | Coach Clarence, shuffling a deck of cards like a teacher about to explain the game

E01-092 | Granddaddy Booker, holding a small potted tree sapling

E01-140 | Granddaddy Booker: an elder passing a wrapped heirloom box to a young adult

E01-141 | Mother Gloria & Mr. Reggie: two elders laughing over an old photo

E01-158 | Brother Walter & Miss Mavis: two elders playing chess on a small folding table

E01-159 | Miss Lula Mae: an elder reading aloud to a small grandchild on their lap

E01-164 | Pops Earl: an elder passing a wrapped heirloom box to a young adult

E01-167 | Granddaddy Booker: an elder and a grandchild fishing off a short dock

E01-171 | Group: three elders on a porch swing deep in conversation

E01-182 | Group: four elders around a kitchen table with coffee mugs, one telling the story

E01-192 | A wooden rocking chair with a knitted throw

E01-193 | A brass pocket watch with an open lid

E01-199 | A chalkboard with 'Lesson #1' written on it

E01-205 | A basket of seed packets

E01-212 | A flat cap hanging on a hook

E01-217 | A fountain pen and ink pot

E01-224 | A bookmark with a tassel

CHAPTER 6

The Things They Never Said Out Loud

[Story for 'The Things They Never Said Out Loud' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 6' in the manuscript file.]

E01-001 | Aunt Birdie, sitting in a rocking chair with one finger raised, mid-lesson

E01-011 | Aunt Hattie, peering over the top of their glasses with a knowing look

E01-027 | Aunt Hattie, pointing at a chalkboard with a wooden pointer

E01-031 | Miss Mavis, holding a stack of handwritten letters tied with string

E01-041 | Miss Lula Mae, holding an old family photo album open

E01-043 | Aunt Hattie, holding an old family photo album open

E01-054 | Coach Clarence, holding a candle in a brass holder

E01-055 | Miss Odessa, holding a candle in a brass holder

E01-076 | Granddaddy Booker, with a hand over the heart, eyes closed

E01-081 | Aunt Birdie, holding an antique oil lantern

E01-105 | Miss Lula Mae, showing a key on a ribbon

E01-107 | Aunt Hattie, holding a map rolled under one arm

E01-111 | Miss Mavis, giving a slow thumbs up with raised eyebrows

E01-112 | Deacon Ross, giving a slow thumbs up with raised eyebrows

E01-114 | Uncle Otis, giving a slow thumbs up with raised eyebrows

E01-122 | Mr. Jasper & Aunt Hattie: two elders playing chess on a small folding table

E01-125 | Mother Gloria & Mr. Reggie: two elders sharing a park bench, one telling a story with big hand gestures

E01-135 | Miss Odessa: an elder reading aloud to a small grandchild on their lap

E01-139 | Mr. Jasper & Aunt Hattie: an elder couple walking arm in arm, one pointing ahead

E01-149 | Aunt Hattie & Uncle Otis: two elders sharing a park bench, one telling a story with big hand gestures

E01-156 | Coach Clarence & Miss Odessa: an elder couple leaning their foreheads together

E01-172 | Group: four elders around a kitchen table with coffee mugs, one telling the story

E01-213 | A wooden chess set mid-game

E01-226 | A heart-shaped locket



“Wisdom Is Earned”

CHAPTER 7

Hands That Build

[Story for 'Hands That Build' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 7' in the manuscript file.]

E01-002 | Uncle Otis, sitting in a rocking chair with one finger raised, mid-lesson

E01-004 | Mr. Jasper, sitting in a rocking chair with one finger raised, mid-lesson

E01-007 | Miss Odessa, reading a thick worn book with a cup of tea balanced on the knee

E01-019 | Mother Gloria, writing in a leather journal with a fountain pen

E01-056 | Brother Walter, carrying a basket of seeds

E01-061 | Miss Vivian, holding a magnifying glass up to one eye

E01-064 | Deacon Ross, holding a magnifying glass up to one eye

E01-083 | Mother Gloria, holding an antique oil lantern

E01-095 | Miss Mavis, holding a small potted tree sapling

E01-098 | Uncle Otis, holding a compass in an open palm

E01-102 | Coach Clarence, showing a key on a ribbon

E01-117 | Grandma Pearl, holding a cup of coffee and laughing softly

E01-123 | Coach Clarence: an elder reading aloud to a small grandchild on their lap

E01-124 | Miss Vivian: an elder and a grandchild planting a seedling together

E01-129 | Miss Odessa & Pops Earl: two elders laughing over an old photo

E01-168 | Pops Earl & Miss Mavis: an elder couple leaning their foreheads together

E01-178 | Group: an elder couple with two grandchildren holding hands in a chain

E01-185 | Group: three elders reading the same newspaper over each other's shoulders

E01-186 | Group: four elders at a graduation, clapping

E01-187 | Group: three elders walking together on a path, canes and all



“Gray Hair, Clear Mind”



“Lessons Learned”



“Respect Your Elders”



“The Long Way Taught Me”



“Roots Run Deep”

CHAPTER 8

Faith and Doubt at the Same Table

[Story for 'Faith and Doubt at the Same Table' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 8' in the manuscript file.]

E01-006 | Coach Clarence, reading a thick worn book with a cup of tea balanced on the knee

E01-016 | Deacon Ross, writing in a leather journal with a fountain pen

E01-020 | Mr. Jasper, writing in a leather journal with a fountain pen

E01-022 | Coach Clarence, holding an old pocket watch up to show it

E01-032 | Deacon Ross, holding a stack of handwritten letters tied with string

E01-037 | Grandma Pearl, tapping their temple with a smile, as if saying 'think'

E01-042 | Mr. Reggie, holding an old family photo album open

E01-048 | Deacon Ross, standing with hands folded behind the back, looking up at the sky

E01-050 | Uncle Otis, standing with hands folded behind the back, looking up at the sky

E01-059 | Aunt Hattie, carrying a basket of seeds

E01-062 | Pops Earl, holding a magnifying glass up to one eye

E01-078 | Pops Earl, with a hand over the heart, eyes closed

E01-084 | Mr. Jasper, holding an antique oil lantern

E01-085 | Grandma Pearl, holding an antique oil lantern

E01-108 | Granddaddy Booker, holding a map rolled under one arm

E01-113 | Aunt Birdie, giving a slow thumbs up with raised eyebrows

E01-118 | Coach Clarence, holding a cup of coffee and laughing softly

E01-127 | Deacon Ross & Mother Gloria: an elder couple walking arm in arm, one pointing ahead

E01-128 | Aunt Hattie: an elder passing a wrapped heirloom box to a young adult

E01-131 | Miss Lula Mae: an elder and a grandchild fishing off a short dock

E01-180 | Group: four elders raising coffee cups in a toast

E01-200 | An old family photo album

E01-221 | A pair of old work boots

E01-232 | Word art: "Been There"

“Been There”



“Learned It the Hard Way”

CHAPTER 9

What I'd Tell My Younger Self

[Story for 'What I'd Tell My Younger Self' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 9' in the manuscript file.]

E01-005 | Grandma Pearl, sitting in a rocking chair with one finger raised, mid-lesson

E01-010 | Mr. Reggie, reading a thick worn book with a cup of tea balanced on the knee

E01-013 | Miss Vivian, peering over the top of their glasses with a knowing look

E01-034 | Uncle Otis, holding a stack of handwritten letters tied with string

E01-038 | Coach Clarence, tapping their temple with a smile, as if saying 'think'

E01-058 | Mr. Reggie, carrying a basket of seeds

E01-094 | Pops Earl, holding a small potted tree sapling

E01-101 | Grandma Pearl, showing a key on a ribbon

E01-115 | Mother Gloria, giving a slow thumbs up with raised eyebrows

E01-121 | Miss Mavis: an elder teaching a grandchild to tie a tie

E01-136 | Pops Earl: an elder and a grandchild planting a seedling together

E01-142 | Mother Gloria: an elder fixing a grandchild's collar before church

E01-157 | Uncle Otis: an elder teaching a grandchild to tie a tie

E01-160 | Deacon Ross: an elder and a grandchild planting a seedling together

E01-170 | Mr. Jasper & Aunt Hattie: two elders playing chess on a small folding table

E01-173 | Group: three elders posing for a group picture, one squinting at the camera

E01-218 | A church fan with a wooden handle

E01-222 | An acorn and an oak leaf

E01-223 | A teapot in cream ceramic

E01-227 | A magnolia branch



“Ask Me How I Know”



“Seasoned”



“Wise Beyond My Years (Finally)”



“Patience Pays”



“Earned Every Gray”

CHAPTER 10

Pass It On

[Story for 'Pass It On' not written yet. Add it under '# Chapter 10' in the manuscript file.]

E01-003 | Mother Gloria, sitting in a rocking chair with one finger raised, mid-lesson

E01-008 | Brother Walter, reading a thick worn book with a cup of tea balanced on the knee

E01-018 | Uncle Otis, writing in a leather journal with a fountain pen

E01-024 | Brother Walter, holding an old pocket watch up to show it

E01-033 | Aunt Birdie, holding a stack of handwritten letters tied with string

E01-044 | Granddaddy Booker, holding an old family photo album open

E01-046 | Pops Earl, standing with hands folded behind the back, looking up at the sky

E01-075 | Aunt Hattie, holding a framed diploma with pride

E01-077 | Miss Vivian, with a hand over the heart, eyes closed

E01-090 | Mr. Reggie, shuffling a deck of cards like a teacher about to explain the game

E01-091 | Aunt Hattie, holding a small potted tree sapling

E01-093 | Miss Vivian, holding a small potted tree sapling

E01-126 | Mr. Jasper: an elder showing a teenager how to balance a checkbook

E01-137 | Miss Mavis & Coach Clarence: two elders sharing a park bench, one telling a story with big hand gestures

E01-145 | Aunt Birdie: an elder teaching a grandchild to tie a tie

E01-146 | Granddaddy Booker & Mother Gloria: two elders playing chess on a small folding table

E01-147 | Brother Walter: an elder reading aloud to a small grandchild on their lap

E01-148 | Miss Mavis: an elder and a grandchild planting a seedling together

E01-151 | Granddaddy Booker & Miss Lula Mae: an elder couple walking arm in arm, one pointing ahead

E01-184 | Group: an elder circle on folding chairs, one holding a talking stick

E01-190 | Group: four elders raising coffee cups in a toast

E01-203 | A compass

E01-207 | A framed diploma

E01-220 | A pocket notebook with a pencil

E01-231 | Word art: "Listen More"

“Listen More”